The Red Ribbon

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 8

A red ribbon rustled on a meadow post. Beneath it hung a folded note. On one side stood a carved ram with magnificent curved horns. On the other stood a small wooden rat with a round nose.

The wagon was quiet now. Its new pin held the loose fitting against the frame. Your original map and three recovered sections rested safely in their folio. Only the final gap remained.

“The ram! Magnificent horns!” Nib exclaimed eagerly.

He took two steps toward it before Lark fluttered to the post.

“Magnificent,” Lark agreed warmly. “But what does the note say?”

Nib came back. The ribbon marked the place where a clue had been left. It did not point toward either animal. Both carvings had a little drawer beneath their feet.

Lark laid the unopened note on the explorer case. Before reading it, she showed you the label on your map folio.

“Try our familiar word first,” Lark invited gently. “Read it right through. What is the last sound in map?”

The folio stayed closed while Lark drew a short line in the journal with a little shoulder near its top.

“This is lowercase r,” Lark explained clearly. “Listen to the start of red and ribbon: /r/. Let your voice begin smoothly. Keep your tongue from tapping or rolling, and don't add an extra vowel. Find r beside m.”

The ribbon moved in a soft breeze. Nib steadied the case so the paper could not flutter away.

Lark placed r beside a and m. She joined all three sounds into ram.

“Ram,” Lark modeled warmly. “Read the whole word with me. The beginning is /r/. The ending is our closed-lip hum.”

Nib glanced fondly at the horns.

“A very well-dressed word,” Nib observed appreciatively.

Lark opened the note. Its first two letters matched ram. Its last letter did not.

Nib leaned forward, then stopped himself.

“I nearly chose before the end,” Nib admitted thoughtfully.

“We have time for the last sound,” Lark reminded him gently.

Before making the choice, she left space beside the ribbon drawing in your journal.

“Write r here,” Lark invited softly. “Down, back toward the top, and over its small shoulder. You can use my mark to help.”

The note lay open between the carvings. Its word was rat.

“This word tells us which carving to use,” Lark encouraged gently. “Try it yourself. You can speak the sounds, join them quietly, or ask for help. Then choose the animal it names.”

The final t changed the destination. At the rat's base, Lark lifted the ordinary little latch. Nib slid the drawer open. Inside lay the fourth and last missing section of your map.

“Small nose. Excellent drawer,” Nib declared delightedly.

Lark set the new section on its backing beside the others. There was the original, the orchard piece, the ridge piece, the island piece, and this final folded piece. Nothing more needed to be found.

In the moonstone's light, a faint route ran toward a drawing of a crooked root. A folded edge hid the rest.

The wind lifted a corner of the note. Lark caught it before the old paper could bend.

“Let's join everything under shelter,” Lark suggested carefully.

Nib looked at the fragile pieces and nodded.

“A grand discovery,” Nib murmured sensibly, “deserves somewhere flat.”

Lark untied the ribbon and tucked it into the journal. It would be useful when your loose adventure pages were ready to become a book.

On today's page she drew both animals, the little clue, and the opened rat drawer.

“Why did the rat lead us to the paper?” Lark asked gently. “Was it the most splendid carving, or did its name match every sound in our note?”

Nib stood beside the picture of the ram for a moment.

“Fine horns,” Nib told it sincerely. “We simply had different business.”

The last piece was safe. Eight journal pages rested together. Ahead was a sheltered clearing where all five sections could finally meet.